

Field Overview: Disciplinary Structure and Growth Dynamics

The Active Inference literature has undergone a phase transition. What originated in the late 2000s as a niche within theoretical neuroscience has expanded rapidly into a multi-disciplinary research program spanning three primary domains and eight tracked categories. Our corpus, extracted from arXiv, Semantic Scholar, and OpenAlex and deduplicated to $N = 849$ papers (2005–2026), captures the breadth, tempo, and internal architecture of this expansion (Figure 1).

